

Exhibit 16

The Times - Engineering crazy idea into a home robotics start-up

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French would be speaking German without us, Trump tells Macron

David Charter Washington

Donald Trump broke off his bromance with President Macron yesterday in a series of tweets that threatened a trade war and criticised the French leader's call for a European army.

The US president told Mr Macron that Parisians would be speaking German today were it not for American

military assistance in two world wars. He also threatened to impose higher tariffs on French wine.

Mr Trump's tweets, after his visit to Paris for First World War commemorations, marked an abrupt end to Mr Macron's 18-month courtship of the US president. The French leader's speech at the weekend warning of the perils of nationalism — a term that Mr Trump

has embraced — prompted an angry riposte from the American president. "Emmanuel Macron suggests building its own army to protect Europe against the US, China and Russia," Mr Trump tweeted. "But it was Germany in World Wars One & Two — How did that work out for France? They were starting to learn German in Paris before the US came along. Pay for Nato or not!"

He went on: "On trade, France makes excellent wine, but so does the US. The problem is that France makes it very hard for the US to sell its wines into France, and charges big tariffs, whereas the US makes it easy for French wines, and charges very small tariffs. Not fair, must change!"

Mr Macron had a "very low approval rating" and "there is no country more

nationalist than France", the US president wrote. In characteristic capital letters he added: "MAKE FRANCE GREAT AGAIN!"

Angela Merkel, the German chancellor, cemented her own relationship with Mr Macron by calling yesterday for "a real, true European army" in a speech to the European parliament. **Merkel snubs 'old allies', page 32**

May accused of betrayal as she unveils Brexit deal

Ministers under pressure to reject agreement

Francis Elliott Political Editor
Bruno Waterfield Brussels
Oliver Wright, Sam Coates

Theresa May will put her future in the hands of senior ministers today as she asks them to sign off a Brexit deal in the face of accusations of betrayal.

The prime minister was trying to sell the divorce deal and pact on the future relationship with Europe last night to a reluctant cabinet, which is due to meet at 2pm to agree it.

Leave-supporting cabinet ministers were coming under intense pressure to reject the deal as senior Brexiters and the DUP launched a pre-emptive strike on what they claimed was an abject surrender.

Mrs May's efforts to secure cabinet backing will be further undermined by a leaked diplomatic note seen by *The Times* spelling out how the EU intends to force Britain to accept a longer-term alignment with its rules.

Despite this, she will claim to have won a crucial battle over the so-called backstop, which comes into force after the transition period and before a final deal on the future relationship.

The EU has dropped its demand for Northern Ireland to remain in the bloc's customs union during this period, which would have meant a border in the Irish Sea. However, Mrs May has agreed that the province must remain more aligned to EU regulations in some areas than the rest of the UK.

In a further concession Mrs May has agreed to "level playing field" measures

tying Britain to EU rules in areas such as state aid and environmental and workers' rights protections during the backstop.

Sabine Weyand, the deputy to Michel Barnier, Europe's chief negotiator, told European ambassadors that this concession would be used as the basis of the future relationship with the EU. She also said that Britain "would have to swallow a link between access to products and fisheries in future agreements", in a leaked note of the meeting on Friday.

"We should be in the best negotiation position for the future relationship. This requires the customs union as the basis of the future relationship," Ms Weyand said. "They must align their rules but the EU will retain all the controls. They apply the same rules. UK wants a lot more from future relationship, so EU retains its leverage."

The briefing underlines fears among Brexiters that the temporary customs union during the backstop will become the long-term basis for the relationship with the EU, prohibiting new trade deals and forcing the government to adopt all new EU rules and regulations regardless of whether they are in Britain's interest.

The leak will appal Brussels as it seeks to provide Mrs May with space and time to secure the backing of her cabinet and the wider Tory party.

Mrs May appeared to have made it to the end of the day without losing any cabinet ministers. However, there were **Continued on page 4, col 3**



Happy birthday, Grandpa The Prince of Wales, who turns 70 today, at Clarence House with his grandson George and other family members in a photograph to mark the occasion. There will be a party at Buckingham Palace this evening. Page 11

Unlucky in love? It's all your mother's fault

Mark Bridge

If you can't hold down a steady relationship, maybe it's time to blame your mother — if you haven't already.

A study using data on thousands of people spanning decades has linked the number of partners an adult has to their mother's romantic history.

For every additional relationship a mother had, the number of partners that her children had increased by an average of 6 per cent, it found.

Previous research has indicated that children of divorced parents are also more likely to divorce. Claire Kamp Dush, of Ohio State University, led the latest study and said that it broadened

the picture. "It's not only divorce now. Many children are seeing their parents divorce, start new cohabiting relationships, and those end as well. All of these relationships can influence children's outcomes," she said.

The research, published in the online journal *Plos One*, may shed light on the personal lives of celebrities such as Judy Garland's daughter Liza Minnelli, 72, who is one short of her mother's tally of five marriages.

The researchers said that their findings did not support the theory that a person's relationships were affected by the economic impact of the parental break-up. Children did not have to witness their parents' break-ups to

repeat the pattern, the research also found. Dr Kamp Dush said: "It could be that mothers who have more partners don't have great relationship skills, or don't deal with conflict well, or have mental health problems, each of which can undermine relationships and lead to instability."

"Whatever the exact mechanisms, they may pass these characteristics on to their children, making their children's relationships less stable."

The researchers used US government data on 7,152 people covering a period of at least 24 years. The surveys included information not only on marriages and divorces but also cohabiting relationships and break-ups.

Engineering crazy idea into a home robotics start-up

Jack Cornes says that his robot business began as a Heath Robinson affair in the garage of his schoolfriend Harry Smith. "Harry is a self-proclaimed mad inventor. His parents asked him to paint the living room, which he found completely boring, so he let his mind wander and came up with a better solution."

The pair, both 20, teamed up to launch Hausbots, which is hoping to develop robots for the construction industry and for household applications; the Birmingham-based company's first product is a painting and decorating robot, and the business hopes to launch commercial trials within four months.

Mr Cornes says that the idea won £10,000 of outside funding last year, which convinced the pair to "turn this engineering project into a business".

The nationwide start-up competition in which they triumphed in 2017, called the F Factor, aims to give young people experience of starting a business as well as introductions to advisers and investors.

"Since winning, we've raised our first investment, hired our first employees

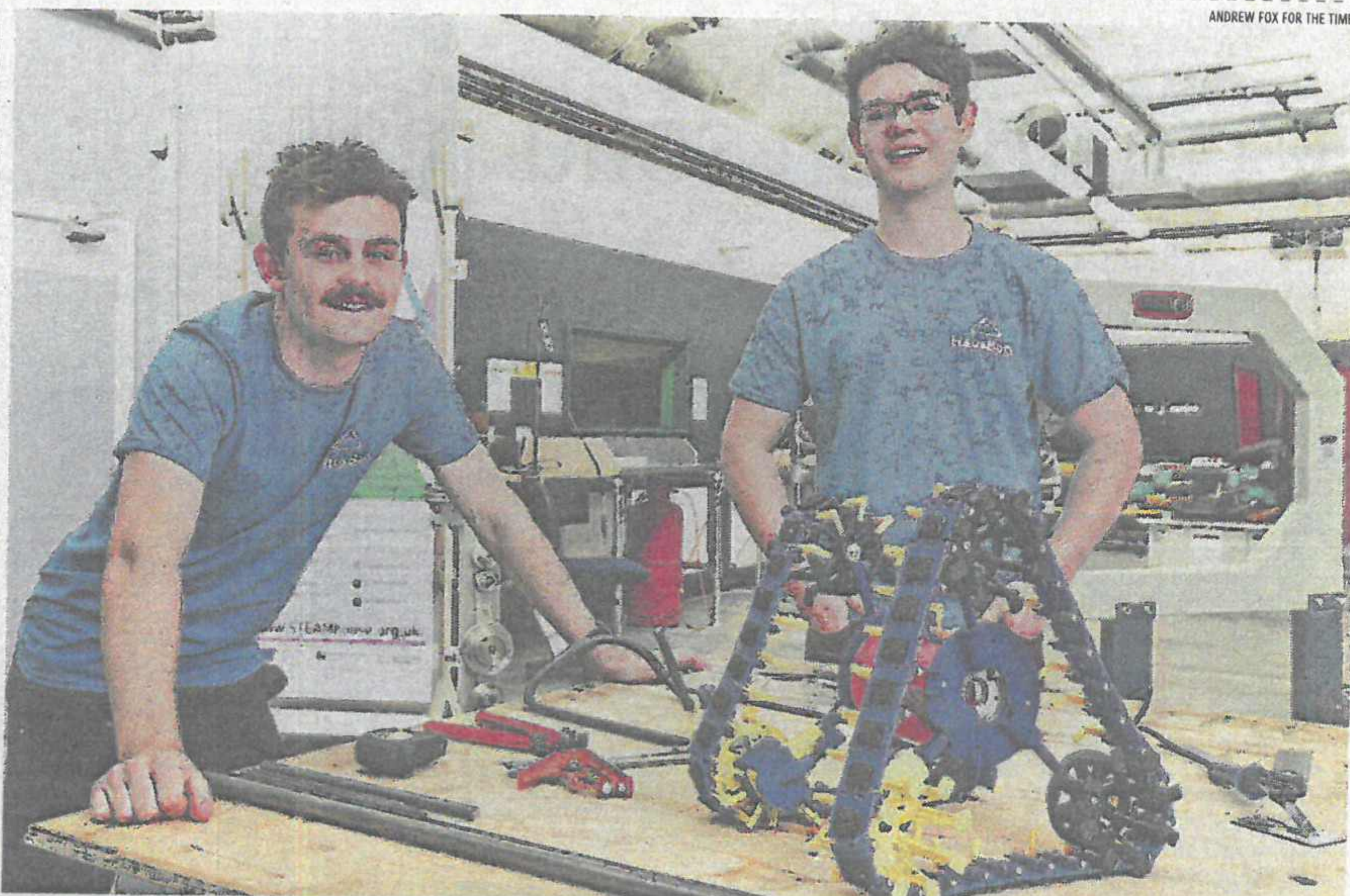
and got ourselves a little office," says Mr Cornes.

Two national winners of this year's scheme will each receive a £10,000 grant, one in the 14 to 18 age category, and the other in the 19 to 25 category. *The Times* will follow the progress of the competition and profile the winners.

Pierre-Simon Ntiruhungwa, a co-founder of the initiative, says the aim is to encourage people from diverse backgrounds to get involved with start-ups. "Too many students in the UK don't have exposure to entrepreneurship, especially in state schools and hard-to-reach areas," he says.

Mr Ntiruhungwa hopes that the competition will provide "a simple yet powerful way for students and young adults to engage with entrepreneurship".

The scheme runs regional and national events, where successful applicants will receive training and advice. Mr Ntiruhungwa says these will benefit entrants regardless of whether they go into further education, conventional employment or start their own business. The competition



Jack Cornes, left, and Harry Smith started Hausbot to get out of painting a room. Below, Kiki Oniwinde's start-up is thriving

is supported by Speakers For Schools, which links state schools and colleges with high-achieving public figures, and Whitehat, a start-up that arranges apprenticeships at leading companies for people who did not go to university. The initiative began at Founders Forum, a private network of some of the world's best-known technology and marketing entrepreneurs and investors.

Mr Cornes says that the F Factor can provide useful introductions. Connections made through the scheme, he says, resulted in Hausbots securing £200,000 in investment from the British Robotics Seed Fund, a

start-up investor. "The F Factor was a kickstart to our business and changed everything," he adds.

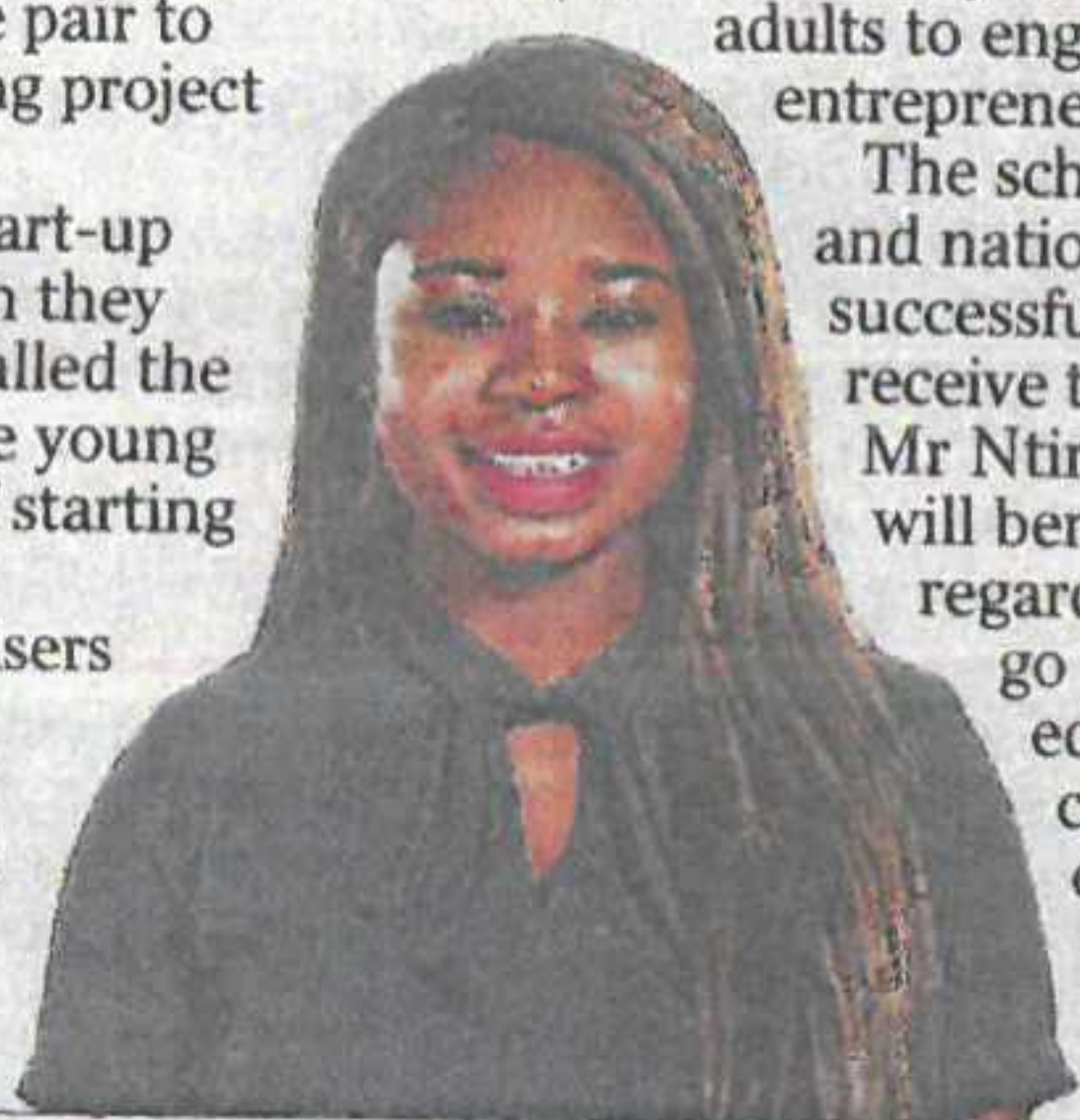
Brent Hoberman, co-founder of the Founders Forum, says he wants the F Factor "to create a platform for secondary schools and universities" and provide young people with "access to entrepreneurship education, world class mentors, technology founders and investors".

Kiki Oniwinde, 26, from Dagenham, won the last leg of the competition this year. She runs BYP Network, a start-up connecting young black professionals with employers and each other. She says she got the

idea from "my experiences of not seeing people that looked like me in the workplace".

Ms Oniwinde founded the company two years ago and held networking events to raise revenues, using the proceeds to build an app, which has had 10,000 downloads. She says: "I found that, being from a disadvantaged background, we don't get much representation. Winning has given me confidence in myself and my ideas. I believe that will happen for other people too."

Participants have until January 31 to enter the competition. For more details visit ffactor.me.



Small firms count the cost of bank branch closures, MPs told

James Hurley Enterprise Editor

Small businesses have been hurt by the closure of thousands of bank branches in recent years, the Banking Standards Board has warned.

Dame Colette Bowe, the organisation's chairwoman, told the Treasury

select committee that the spate of closures was "very much a small business issue". She said: "If you are trying to bank your takings and you have to drive 20 miles... that's not good."

Which?, the consumer group, said in June that about 60 bank branches were closing every month. Royal Bank of

Scotland, Britain's largest banker of small companies, is shutting the most. The closures leave small businesses suffering from declining footfall in town centres and a shortage of withdrawal and deposit facilities.

MPs and business and consumer groups alike are concerned that it is the

most vulnerable and isolated customers who are being hit hardest by the closures, as banks slash their branch networks in response to the rise of online banking.

Alison Cottrell, chief executive of the standards board, told MPs that banks should work together to discuss branch

closures and branch sharing to minimise the impact on customers.

Dame Colette said the issue "needs to get higher up everybody's agenda" and that she was not happy about the industry's response so far. She said she had taken it up with the banking industry's trade body, UK Finance.

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